Administrative and Technology Support Services for the NIH Peer Review Program with the Center for Scientific Review (CSR)

Small Business Sources Sought Notice

Solicitation No. 75N92021R0029

CONTRACTING OFFICE ADDRESS

Department of Health and Human Services, National Institutes of Health, National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI), Office of Acquisitions, 6705 Rockledge Drive, RKL1, MSC 7902, Bethesda, MD, 20892-7902, UNITED STATES

INTRODUCTION

This is a Small Business Sources Sought notice set-aside exclusively for 8(a) contractors under the 8(a) Business Development Program. This is **NOT** a solicitation for proposals, proposal abstracts, or quotations. The purpose of this notice is to obtain information regarding: (1) the availability and capability of qualified 8(a) small business sources; and (2) their size classification relative to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) code for the proposed acquisition. Your responses to the information requested will assist the Government in determining the appropriate acquisition method, including whether an 8(a) small business set-aside is possible. **An organization that is not considered an 8(a) small business under NAICS code 561110 – Office Administrative Services, with a small business size standard of $8.0M, should not submit a response to this notice.**

BACKGROUND

With the advent of the e-Grants electronic submittal requirements in May 2007, the National Institutes of Health (NIH), Center for Scientific Review (CSR) performs a wide range of information technology-driven and support activities to further CSR's mission as the portal for NIH grant applications and their review for scientific merit. CSR receives approximately 100,000 grant applications per year and organizes peer review groups or "study sections" that evaluate the majority (70%) of the research grant applications submitted to NIH. CSR additionally receives and coordinates the review of grant applications of other operating divisions within the US Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS).

CSR's mission is to ensure that NIH grant applications receive fair, independent, expert, and timely reviews, so ultimately NIH can fund the most promising research. In the last 12 months, CSR received and processed approximately 100,000 grant applications. Most of these applications are reviewed by study sections administered by CSR's 25 IRGs, which are presently organized into five (5) CSR Divisions. Approximately 231 Scientific Review Officers (SROs) coordinate the activities across the 25 IRGs. The SROs work in partnership with the scientific community to ensure that each scientific review group (study section) identifies the most meritorious science for recommended funding by the NIH's 27 Extramural Institutes and Centers.

PROJECT REQUIREMENTS

1. Support Services for the Operation of the Division Integrated Review Groups (IRGs)

Representative activities that shall be performed by Contractor staff, under the proposed requirement, include, but are not limited to:

- Operational Services for IRG Chiefs: The Contractor shall provide essential administrative and technology support to the 25 IRG Chiefs. The Contractor shall work closely with the IRG Chief to ensure a wide array of administrative and technology support services are provided, as well as the work with the chiefs' subordinate staff of approximately 8 to 11 Scientific Review Officers (SROs). The Contractor shall learn about IRG and CSR review processes, policies, and procedures and comply with them to ensure accuracy and timeliness of work products. The Contractor shall also work closely with federal administrative staff to gain knowledge, skills, and abilities to perform administrative work in compliance with CSR, NIH, HHS, and Federal rules and regulations.

    - Support Services for Scientific Review Officers (SROs)
    - Support of Scientific Review Meetings
    - Support for Video Assisted Meetings (VAM)
    - IRG-specific Quality Assurance Activities
    - Ancillary Program Services: Provide Events Management Coordination

2. Support Services for the Operation of the Division of Receipt and Referral (DRR)

The DRR is the central office that receives all incoming grant applications to the NIH (approximately 100,000 annually). The Contractor shall work closely with DRR staff to learn and comply with receipt and referral rules, regulations, policies, and procedures in order to accomplish work with accuracy and integrity. The DRR works closely with CSR to route grant applications to the 24 IRGs for further processing. The Contractor shall provide direct support to the Director, DRR, senior management and other staff.

- Electronic Receipt and Processing of Grant Applications
- DRR Quality Analytical Activities

3. Support Services for the Division of Management Services

- Subject Matter Expert in Human Resources: The CSR requires technical assistance in the areas of human resources, ethics, and administrative office support.
- Support for the Executive Officer (EO): The CSR requires Administrative and Analytical Support to the EO.
- Support for the Administrative Services Branch Office Support
- Administrative Support across areas including DMS and IRG Divisions

4. Support Services for the Office of the Director

- Administrative Office Support

- Ancillary OD Program Services:

    - Support CSR Early Career Reviewer Program
    - Support Advisory Council to the Director on Diversity Working Group Subcommittee on Peer Review
    - Subject Matter Expert: Operations Management Support for the Office of Planning, Analysis and Evaluation (OPAE)
    - Support for the Office of Planning, Analysis and Evaluation (OPAE)
    - Support for the Ethics Program
    - Support to the Information Management Branch (IMB): Support for the Director of Information Management Branch
    - Support for Video Assisted Meetings (VAM)

5. Scientific Review and Evaluation Activities (SREA) Program Services

NIH/CSR Centralized SREA Program is a central service management center responsible for managing and evaluating costs associated with NIH peer review to CSR and 27 NIH Institutes and Centers. The SREA Management and Service Center (MSC) coordinates the processing of reviewer payment reimbursement for honoraria, travel, hotel lodging, meals, incidentals, and other approved costs. As part of this process, SREA staff interacts regularly with reviewers in answering questions, assisting with the submission of reimbursement documentation and the procedures that surround it, and resolving reimbursement problems.

The NIH SREA Centralized Program processes meeting rosters for CSR and ICs for payment reimbursement to over 35,000 reviewers per year and submits directly to the NIH Office of Financial Management (OFM) for a wireless payment. The Contractor shall coordinate and manage a high volume of time sensitive transactions requiring detailed attention to accuracy of the data. In addition, the Contractor shall coordinate the Government fiduciary service related to non-federal reviewer travel payment to the NIH/CSR travel contractor. The ability to communicate, collaborate, and coordinate with all leadership components of CSR, NIH Institute Extramural Program Officials, Administrators, and leading scientific reviewers across the country is critical.

- SREA Website Support: The Contractor shall provide staff with the expertise necessary to maintain and update content on the SREA web pages in both the NIH Intranet and internet domains in support of the NIH public.

CAPABILITY STATEMENTS

8(a) small business concerns that believe they possess the capabilities necessary to undertake this work should submit complete documentation of their capabilities to the Contracting Officer. The capability statements **must** specifically address **each** project requirement separately. Additionally, the capability statement should include: 1) the total number of employees; 2) the professional

qualifications of scientists, medical experts, and technical personnel as it relates to the above outlined requirements; 3) a description of general and specific facilities and equipment available, including computer equipment and software; 4) an outline of previous research projects that are similar to the project requirements in which the organization and proposed personnel have participated; and 5) any other information considered relevant to this program. The capability statement must not exceed ten (10) single sided or 5 double sided pages in length and using an 11-point font size minimum.

Interested 8(a) small business organizations are required to identify their size standards in accordance with the Small Business Administration. The Government requests that no proprietary or confidential business data be submitted in a response to this notice. However, responses that indicate the information therein is proprietary will be properly safeguarded for Government use only. Capability statements must include the name and telephone numbers of a point of contact having authority and knowledge to discuss responses with Government representatives. Capability statements in response to this market survey that do not provide sufficient information for evaluation will be considered non-responsive. When submitting this information, please reference the solicitation notice number 75N92021R0029.

All capability statements sent in response to this Sources Sought Notice must be submitted electronically (via e-mail) to Linda Smith, Contracting Officer, at Linda.Smith2@nih.gov and copy Sarah Bank, Contracting Officer, at Sarah.Bank@nih.gov in either MS Word or Adobe Portable Document Format (PDF), by the requested due date of April 12, 2021. All responses must be received by the specified due date and time in order to be considered.

The solicitation release date is pending. The Government intends to potentially negotiate one (1) Firm-Fixed-Price/Time-and-Materials type contract, for a one (1) year base period with four (4) consecutive one (1) year options; with an approximate award date of July 8, 2021.

Disclaimer and Important Notes. This notice does not obligate the Government to award a contract or otherwise pay for the information provided in the response. The Government reserves the right to use information provided by respondents for any purpose deemed necessary and legally appropriate. Any organization responding to this notice should ensure that its response is complete and sufficiently detailed to allow the Government to determine the organization's qualifications to perform the work. Respondents are advised that the Government is under no obligation to acknowledge receipt of the information received or provide feedback to respondents with respect to any information submitted. After a review of the responses received, a combined synopsis/solicitation may be published in Beta.Sam.gov. However, responses to this notice will not be considered adequate responses to a solicitation.

Confidentiality. No proprietary, classified, confidential, or sensitive information should be included in your response. The Government reserves the right to use any non-proprietary technical information in any resultant solicitation(s).

ORIGINAL POINT OF CONTACT

Linda Smith, Contracting Officer, Branch A, Section 2, OA, NHLBI, Phone (301) 827-7741, E-mail: Linda.Smith2@nih.gov

Sarah Bank, Contracting Officer, Branch A, Section 2, OA, NHLBI, Phone (301) 827-7741, E-mail: Sarah.Bank@nih.gov.

Submission Instructions:

Interested parties shall submit capability statements via the FedConnect web portal (www.fedconnect.net) and reference the FedConnect Sources Sought Number 75N92021R0029. The due date for receipt of capability statements is **3:00 p.m. Eastern Time on April 12, 2021**. Vendors can register with FedConnect at https://www.fedconnect.net/FedConnect/default.htm.

Please note that FedConnect is used by multiple federal agencies, and therefore, FedConnect assistance will be provided by Compusearch Software Systems, not the NHLBI OA. More information about registration requirements can be found by downloading the FedConnect Ready, Set, Go! Guide at https://www.fedconnect.net/fedconnect/Marketing/Documents/FedConnect_Ready_Set_Go.pdf.

For assistance in registering or for other FedConnect technical questions, please call the FedConnect Help Desk at (800) 899-6665 or email at support@fedconnect.net. Please use the Contracting Officer/ Contract Specialist contact information provided, should you require a waiver not to use FedConnect for submitting.

All responses must be received by the specified due date and time in order to be considered.